went back to the professor who had pointed him in this direction, Christian Imbert, and asked whether he could try to do this experiment in his lab. Imbert "said look, I don't understand what you tell me, but it looks interesting, so go to Geneva, talk to John Bell," Aspect said. "If John Bell tells you that it is interesting, then I will offer you the possibility to do it in my lab."

So Aspect went down to Geneva in the spring of 1975 to meet with Bell, just as Bell was starting to organize the conference in Erice. "I explained to him my idea, and he said nothing, he was very quiet," Aspect recalled. "And then the first question [he asked] was, 'do you have a permanent position?'" Aspect was confused. "I said, why are you asking me [this] question? He said, 'answer first.'" So Aspect explained that his position was, in fact, permanent—despite the fact that he was still working on his PhD, his lecturer position at the Institut d'Optique had the French equivalent of tenure. Satisfied, Bell explained his question to Aspect. "This kind of physics is not popular at all," he said, "and so you are going to have difficulties. So I would not recommend that you go into that if you are not tenured." Keenly aware of the professional dangers that came with work in foundations of quantum physics, Bell had made a habit of discouraging young physicists from pursuing the subject until they were more established in their careers. But Aspect, thankfully, was already safe. "Then he strongly encouraged me," Aspect recalled. "He told me that it was really *the* experiment to do. He told me, if you can do an experiment where you change the orientation of the polarizers while the photons are in flight, yes, this is [the]real experiment to do."

Aspect returned to Paris and got to work assembling his experiment in Imbert's lab. "Basically I borrowed everything, except for one thing, at one point I needed to buy a laser," Aspect said. "So I got the money to buy one laser. That's the only grant I got. All the rest is equipment borrowed here and there. Or built in the workshops of the Institut. I had no competition, so I was not under pressure. Nobody was interested." Over the course of the next six years, Aspect assembled and tested the delicate experimental equipment, eventually pulling in an undergraduate, Phillip Grangier, an intern, Jean Dalibard, and a research engineer, Gérard Roger, to help. Meanwhile, unbeknownst to Aspect, Imbert was shielding him from the criticisms and concerns of the rest of the institute. "Imbert acted as an